

Story Seven

Be Still

Spotlight: Manny · Herb: Tulsi (Holy Basil)

If God designed everything perfectly, why doesn't my body work?

The car door slammed too hard and Manny was already laughing before he hit the porch step.

"Vovó!" He yelled it from the driveway. "Vovó, I bought you something at the gas station and I don't think you want it."

She did not yell back. Vovó did not yell at things from across yards. She came to the screen door, looked at him over her reading glasses, and waited.

He held up the bag. "Beef jerky. The expensive kind."

"Ai meu Deus."

"You said the cheap kind tasted like a shoe."

"It does." She held the door open with one bare foot the way she always did when her hands were busy. "Come inside, Emmanuel. You're letting the heat in."

Emmanuel. Not Manny. Manny noticed the way he always noticed those things, half a second after they happened, when noticing didn't help. He stepped inside.

He'd driven eleven hours with the AC turned up too high and the worship playlist that had been on rotation at camp on repeat the whole way, and somewhere south of Atlanta he had realized he could not remember what the highway had looked like for the last forty miles. He had pulled over

at a gas station, eaten a bag of pretzels, checked his blood sugar, and not looked at the number. He had not looked at the number on the long drive after, either. He had only known he was getting close to home when the trees started to look right.

The camp was Word of Life's, the one they run every summer out of Hudson, Florida, and Manny had been going down there since he was fourteen. Seven summers. Never once as a camper. He had gone down the first year as camp crew, which is what they call the kids who run the place from underneath. He washed dishes that whole summer until the skin split at his knuckles, and after that they put him on the go-karts. Crew did not get a cabin or a list of names. What crew got was the dish line and the track and nine weeks of walking past every kid at that camp four times a day.

And in two weeks he was driving all eleven hours back down there, because the Bible institute at Hudson was where he started in the fall. After that, Hudson would stop being a place he went in June and left in August. It would be the place he lived.

There was a thing that had happened in week six that he had not told anybody. It was not even a big thing. They moved a staff meeting and changed the schedule, and that was the whole of it, and he had come apart about it in front of four other guys on crew, loud, in a way he could still hear

when it got quiet. Then he had gone out to the dock and cried about coming apart. Then he had gone back inside and apologized to all four of them by name. That was the whole shape of him and he knew it. Everything went all the way in and everything came all the way back out, and there was no place in the middle where a thing could be set down for a minute and left there.

The kitchen smelled like something that had been simmering since morning. There was a basket of tulsi on the counter that he could smell before he could see it, the sharp clove-and-pepper smell that made his eyes water a little when he breathed in too fast.

"You cut this today?"

"This morning. Before the heat."

Manny leaned over the basket and breathed in and stood back up. The blood went somewhere it had not gone in a while (sideways, or down, or behind his eyes for a second) and he put his hand on the counter without thinking about it. The counter was there. It had been there his whole life. He had just never needed it to hold him up before.

Vovó didn't look up. "Did you check?"

"Yeah."

"What was it?"

"A number." He smiled. "Don't worry, Vovó, I corrected for it. Pump's doing its thing."

She ground something for another moment. "Sit."

"I'm fine. I'm just..."

"Sit, Manny."

He sat. The stool was the same stool he'd sat on as a kid waiting for snacks and as a teenager waiting for lectures that never came. Vovó had a particular gift for asking him to sit and then not making him talk about anything for a very long time. The mortar and pestle continued. The herbs in the basket continued. Out on the porch the boards took PopPop's weight and gave it back, once, and were quiet.

Manny watched her grind. He had not seen her do this in maybe a year and a half. His own hands felt funny. He looked at them and saw the small bruise where last week's infusion set had gone in. He saw the faint shadow on his forearm from his CGM sensor, the little monitor he had reset two days ago. He saw the dry patches across his knuckles, the ones that always showed up when his blood sugar had been ragged for a stretch. He put his hands back on the counter.

"You drove a long way," Vovó said.

"Eleven hours."

"From camp."

"From camp."

"Mm." She set down the pestle. "How was camp."

It was the question he had been ready for. He'd been ready for it the whole drive home. He had a whole answer assembled. The worship sets that had landed. The boy who had come through the go-kart line every single afternoon for five days and had not said one word to anybody, not to his counselors, not to the kids in his cabin, and who had said the whole thing out loud at the campfire on the last night. The way the sun had set on the lake while the fire went up and every kid in the ring stood there holding a stick. He had the answer. He opened his mouth.

"It was good," he said.

Vovó did not say anything. She picked up the pestle.

"It was really good." He could hear himself saying it. "I think it was... I think a lot happened. The kids were really receptive. There was this one girl on Thursday..."

"Manny."

He stopped.

"How was camp."

He looked at his hands again.

"Long," he said.

"Mm."

"Hot. The heat was... it was a thing. I drank like four gallons of water a day and it didn't matter."

"And eating?"

"Whenever. Late. Sometimes not."

"And sleep?"

He laughed, but the laugh came out wrong. "I'm twenty, Vovó. I don't sleep."

She picked up the basket of tulsi and brought it to the counter in front of him. She did not say anything about sleep. She did not say anything about eating. She did not say anything about the laugh. She just set the basket down where he could smell it, took a sprig of fresh tulsi out of it,

crushed one leaf between her thumb and forefinger, and held it under his nose.

"What do you notice."

He noticed everything at once, which was the problem.

He noticed that the smell was warmer than peppermint and sharper than basil and somehow had a clove note he couldn't place. He noticed that his shoulders had been somewhere up near his ears for the last three weeks and that they had just dropped about half an inch. He noticed that his throat was tight and that breathing through his nose was suddenly easier than it had been since he got in the car. He noticed that Vovó had not looked at him directly once since he sat down on the stool, and that this was kindness, not indifference. He noticed that there was a glass jar on the counter that had not been there before, an empty glass jar with a wooden lid, the kind she used for things that had to wait.

"It's... sharp. Spicy." He thought about it. "Clove-ish."

"Mm. Smell again."

He did. "Warm. Like..." He searched. "Like something you'd hold a baby in."

She smiled at that. She did not say anything, but she smiled,

and Manny realized that he had said the right thing and that he had not been trying to.

"Tulsi," she said. "Holy basil. Some people call it the Queen of Herbs."

"That's a brag."

"She earned it." Vovó took the sprig back and dropped it into the empty glass jar. "What does the body do when there is too much."

"Too much what."

"Pick one. Heat. Stress. Sugar. Sound. Whatever you want."

Manny thought about it. "It... adjusts?"

"How."

"It... I don't know. Sweats. Pumps more insulin. Makes more cortisol, which is the hurry-up hormone. There's a feedback loop."

"There's a feedback loop." Vovó nodded once. "And what happens to the feedback loop when there is too much of too many things for too long."

He looked at his hands again.

"It..." he said. "It stops adjusting. Or it adjusts in a way that... that costs something."

"Mm."

She poured raw honey into the jar, slow, the way honey goes when it is fresh, a single amber rope that thickened as it fell and made a quiet pile at the bottom around the tulsi sprigs, until the leaves were half-covered. Then she opened the bottle of apple cider vinegar she kept on the counter, the one with the mother cloudy at the bottom, and poured that on top until the jar was nearly full. The honey did not want to mix with the vinegar yet. It made cloudy ribbons that hung in the liquid the way clouds hang in mountains, and then slowly, slowly, the whole jar began to look like one thing instead of two. She fitted the wooden lid. She set the jar in front of him.

"This is what."

"Oxymel."

"What does it do."

"Honey and vinegar. Extracts whatever the herb does. Both warm. Both shelf-stable."

"And the herb."

"Tulsi is... it's an adaptogen. It works on the HPA axis. Helps the body's stress response not overshoot. It's a nervine, too. And anti-inflammatory."

"In English."

He almost smiled. "It helps a body that has been under too much for too long come back to the middle. It settles the nerves down. And it takes some of the heat out of a place that is swollen and sore."

"Better." She reached past him for the honey. "Say it that way to somebody who needs it. Nobody was ever comforted by the word axis."

"Where did people learn this?"

He paused. He saw where she was going. "India. Ayurvedic tradition. It's a sacred herb there. They call it tulasi. Vedic literature. Thousands of years."

"And we are not Hindu."

"No."

"So."

He looked at her. She was already looking at him, which was rare, and which meant the question mattered.

"So the herb knows what it does whether the person growing it knows the right name for God or not," he said.

"Mm." She picked up the jar and shook it once, gently. The tulsi rose and settled. "God gave it to grow. People paid attention. The paying attention is the part we can borrow. The Person we give the praise to. That part doesn't move."

He thought about the verse in Psalm 19, the one that says the heavens are telling the glory of God. The same plant, growing in Tennessee dirt and growing in Indian dirt, saying the same thing about the same Designer in both places, whether or not anybody standing over it knew His name. He did not say any of that out loud. He just watched her shake the jar.

She set the jar down and wiped her hands on the towel over her shoulder, and then she did something she almost never did in the middle of a working morning. She pulled the second stool out with her foot and sat down on it.

"Two weeks," she said.

"Yes ma'am."

"You will be the third one out of this house to go down there." She folded the towel once on her knee. "I have that same paper in a box in my closet."

Manny turned his head. "You went to Word of Life?"

"I did."

"I didn't know that."

"You did not ask." She said it without any weight on it at all. "Your father went too, the year he turned nineteen. He came home from a spring break with your mother's name in his mouth and no way on earth to get back to her, because he did not own a car."

"Spring break."

"There was a hurricane coming and the school sent them all off, and he went with his resident assistant, and his resident assistant had a girl, and the girl had a sister." Vovó smiled down at the mortar. "One week. He came back in love and he stayed that way, and that sister has been feeding you your whole life."

Manny laughed.

Then she straightened the towel on her shoulder, and the laugh went out of the kitchen the way it does when somebody older changes the subject without raising her voice.

"Come home at Thanksgiving," she said. "Not to be looked

at. So I can feed you."

"Yes ma'am."

She picked the pestle back up. Then, without turning around:

"What was the number."

He did not say anything.

"Emmanuel."

"People ask," he said. "I tell them it's fine."

Vovó ground for a moment. Then she nodded once, slowly, the way she nodded when somebody had just confirmed a thing she had already written down.

"Then you have work to do before Thanksgiving," she said. "Nobody can build one single thing on a man who tells them it is fine."

The screen door opened. PopPop came in with two coffee mugs and a section of the newspaper folded under his arm. He looked at Manny on the stool. He looked at the oxymel jar on the counter.

"You back."

"Yes sir."

"Mm." PopPop set the coffee on the table. "Hoodie's bunched."

Manny looked down. The waistband of his hoodie had snagged on the corner of his pump and was pulling the tubing sideways. He fixed it. PopPop did not watch him fix it. PopPop was already pouring cream into Vovó's mug.

"Kyle Grey called your daddy on Sunday," he said. He said it without any particular emphasis. "Pastor Kyle. Man that runs the camp."

"Yes sir."

"Said there was a boy down there hadn't said a word to anybody the whole five days he was at that camp." PopPop stirred Vovó's coffee. "Said you got it out of him at the fire on the last night. Said nobody put you on that boy. Said you just kept finding him."

Manny did not know what to do with his face.

"Your daddy preaches at folks," PopPop said. "You sit down next to them and wait till they crack. Two different gifts. Don't go trading yours for his."

"Yes sir."

"Be still, though." He tapped the spoon on the rim of the mug and set it down. "You poured out of you all summer. Nothing poured back in. Be still and let it work in you, too. Not just out of you."

He handed Vovó her mug, kissed her on the temple without looking up from his newspaper, and walked out onto the porch.

Manny sat on the stool. The oxymel jar was warm under his palm where he hadn't realized he was touching it.

Bear had gotten interested in the empty tulsi basket.

He approached it the way he approached most things now, with a slow, deliberate dignity that Manny did not remember from before. He put his nose into the basket and smelled it for a long time. Then he sneezed once, looked at it with a kind of resigned professionalism, and lay back down on the kitchen floor without making any further investigation. He had not knocked it over. He had assessed the situation, made a decision, and chosen rest.

"He's getting old, Vovó."

"He is."

"He doesn't..." Manny stopped. "He doesn't move like he used to."

"No."

"That used to be fun for him." Manny gestured vaguely at the basket. "The whole... knocking-things-over thing."

"Mm. It's still fun." Vovó was rinsing her hands. "He just only does it now when it's worth it."

Manny laughed once, soft. He looked down at Bear, and Bear looked back with the steady patience of a creature who had learned, the slow way, what was worth standing up for. Manny thought about the campfire on the last night. The ring of boys with sticks in their hands, each one saying out loud the thing he was done carrying, and then putting the stick in the fire. And afterwards he had stayed up past midnight with the quiet boy, because he could not sit down, and because he could not stop feeling all of it. He had not chosen any of it, exactly. He had just kept going because going was the only direction he knew. He was twenty and Bear was twelve, and somewhere in there was math he had not done yet.

The garden in late August was a different garden than the garden in May. The basil had bolted. The tomatoes had gone leggy. The peppers were in the heavy part of their production, the part where you stopped admiring them and started giving them away. Manny walked between the raised beds with the oxymel jar in his hoodie pocket and tried to remember what each plant was. He had grown up watching

Vovó plant every one of these and he could not name them. The shame of it sat with him for a minute.

Evie was sitting on the back step with her journal open. She did not look up when he came around the corner of the house. She rarely did. Evie had a particular gift for letting other people decide whether they wanted to be noticed.

"Hey, Eve."

"Hey."

He sat down on the step next to her. She kept writing. He looked at the garden. The sun was starting its low slide toward the tree line, which was the part of the day at the homestead that he had always loved best as a kid, the part where the light got honey-colored and everything looked like it had been pre-approved by God.

"Evie."

"Mm."

"Can I ask you something weird."

"Probably."

"If God designed everything perfectly," he said, and he heard his own voice say it before he had decided to say it, "why

doesn't my body work."

Evie did not look up.

She kept writing for another moment. Then she closed her journal, slowly, with her finger holding her place, and she did not say anything for long enough that Manny started to think she had not heard him.

Then she said, "What part of it doesn't work."

He laughed, but it came out short and not quite a laugh. "All of it. Most of it. The pancreas, obviously. The..."

"Manny."

He stopped.

"What part of it doesn't work."

She still had not looked up. The journal was closed in her lap. Her finger was still holding her place. She was, Manny realized, asking it the way Vovó asked things, not because she did not know what he meant, but because she was waiting for him to know what he meant.

He sat with the question.

"The part that... the part that's supposed to handle stress

without falling apart," he said. "The part that's supposed to bounce back. The part that's supposed to... I don't know. Work the way it would if I hadn't been born with this."

"The terrain part."

He looked at her. "When did you learn that word."

"Vovó." She opened her journal again. "Last spring."

"Mm." He looked at the garden. "Yeah. The terrain part."

"That part isn't broken." She wrote something. "It's just under a lot."

He thought about that.

"Tulsi is for the terrain part," she added, and he understood, distantly and with a kind of quiet shock, that his sister had been listening to Vovó for years longer than he had realized.

"Yeah."

"Insulin is for the part that doesn't make insulin anymore. Tulsi is for the part underneath that, the part that's still trying to run the whole rest of the body while your pancreas takes a permanent vacation." She wrote another sentence. "Vovó says the terrain is what was designed. The pancreas thing happened. The terrain is still there."

He sat with that for a while.

The garden was making the small evening sounds it made. The peppers were ticking faintly under their own weight. The cicadas were starting up over by the back fence, the long warm-up note that meant they had only just begun, the one that would not stop until well after dark.

He thought about all the things Vovó had taught him when he was small that he had not remembered he had learned. The names of the herbs by their leaves. The reason you crushed a sprig between your fingers before you decided what it was. The way she watched a tea steep: that she did not watch it impatiently but watched it the way you watch a kettle you trust. He had not noticed at the time that he was learning anything. He had only known that the kitchen smelled good and that Vovó's voice was a thing he wanted nearby.

He wondered when Evie had started to know all the things he no longer remembered.

"Eve."

"Mm."

"When did you start writing in the journal."

She thought about it. "Right after the tulsi. So a year ago."

"A year ago."

"Vovó said writing helps people who feel too much."

Manny laughed. "She said that to you?"

"She said it about Hildegard. I figured it counted."

"Who's Hildegard."

Evie smiled at her journal but did not look up. "Ask her."

Manny let the name sit there unanswered, which he suspected was the point.

The screen door clicked.

Vovó came out with the oxymel jar in her hand. The same jar he had left on the counter. She did not say anything about him leaving it. She handed it to him, and she put one hand briefly on the back of his neck, and she said, "Two weeks. Shake it once a day until you go, and it will be on the shelf when you come home. When it is ready, so are you, and then we ask the right questions."

"Yes ma'am."

"And, minha filha." She turned to Evie. "Tell your brother what you wrote."

Evie looked up for the first time. She blinked at her grandmother. She looked at her journal. She looked at Manny.

"I wrote that he's tired."

Manny laughed. The real kind.

"You wrote that I'm tired."

"Yes."

"That's it?"

"I underlined it."

Vovó went back inside. The screen door closed behind her. The sun finished its slide. The garden held still in the honey light for a moment that Manny did not realize he was paying attention to until it had already gone past.

He looked at the oxymel jar in his hand. The tulsi had risen toward the top. The honey was settling. The vinegar was doing whatever vinegar did when no one was watching.

He tucked it back into his hoodie pocket.

"Eve."

"Mm."

"If I'd asked Vovó that question, what I asked you. What do you think she would've said."

Evie thought about it. She was still looking at the garden.

"I think," she said, "she would've asked you what part of you doesn't work."

He smiled.

"And then?"

"And then she'd have given you tulsí. And she'd have made you sit." Evie tapped her pen against her journal. "And she would've waited."

He nodded.

He did not move from the step. The pump hummed once at his hip, the small mechanical voice of something doing its job.

He had been moving since May. He had driven eleven hours to get here and he had not sat down once since he arrived, not really, and now he was sitting down, and the garden was going on without needing one thing from him.

He let his hands stay where they were, open on his knees,
and he did not get up.

Story Seven: Be Still

Let It Work in You, Too

1. What does Manny bring Vovó from the gas station?

2. Why does Manny grab the counter in the kitchen?

3. What three things go into Vovó's jar of oxymel?

4. Why does Vovó call him "Emmanuel" instead of "Manny" when he arrives?

5. Why does PopPop warn Manny not to trade his gift for his daddy's?

6. Manny first says camp was "good." What clue shows it was harder than that?

7. Evie says the terrain part 'isn't broken,' just 'under a lot.' What does she mean, and how does tulsi help?

8. Manny says tulsi "knows what it does" no matter who grows it. Who does the praise belong to? Use the story.

9. Why is sitting still harder for Manny than driving eleven hours?

10. When you feel tired or upset, what helps you be still? What could you try this week?
